Works of *Locke*

His important works are 'Letter Concerning Toleration' (1689), an 'Essay Concerning Human Understanding' (1690), 'Two Treatises on Civil Government' (1690), 'A Second Letter on Toleration' (1692)), 'A Third Letter on Toleration' (1692), 'A Fourth on Toleration' (1693) and 'Some Thoughts Concerning Education' (1693).

Central Ideas

Locke's central ideas can be discussed as follows:

Conception of Human Nature

Unlike ***Hobbes***, ***Locke*** does not subscribe to a pessimistic view of human nature. He identifies reason as the factor which shapes a rational human being. He also acknowledges reason as the foundation of individual and social life. Humans were social, rational, decent, mentally stable and capable of self-rule. ***Locke***an view also upholds the natural state of equality for individuals. To him, humans are entitled to natural liberty. It is qualified as an inherent privilege to be free from any superior element but to be subversive towards the "dictate of the nature". He also reaches a consensus on the fact that individuals are prone to some degrees of discrepancies in terms of intelligence, strength and their skills. Nevertheless, his reliance on similarities among individuals were outweighing the differences. ***Locke*** is also particular in reflecting the utilitarian trait of humans. Following the line of Bentham, ***Locke*** says, humans seek to strike a balance of pleasure over pain. It is this notion of pleasure or utility which forms the basis of his covenant.

State of Nature

The ***Locke*** an contemplation on the state of nature can be found in his "Second Treatise". In contrast to the ***Hobbes***ian state of nature, ***Locke*** postulates a peaceful condition by virtue of the social instinct of humans. As dictated by the canons of natural law, his state of nature is based on perfect freedom. Moreover, the phase is also characterised by equality defined in terms of reciprocal power and jurisdiction. In his own words, "state of nature is a state of peace, goodwill, mutual assistance and preservation". In short, ***Locke*** underscores the optimistic nature of human beings.

Natural law is considered to be the source of both rights and duties. Humans derive their rights from the domain of natural law and it expects them to respect the ordained rights on a mutual basis for safeguarding the same. ***Locke*** goes to the extent of denoting natural law as the moral law enacted by God, which is sensible through reason. It would not be wrong to refer his state of nature as "an anarchist's paradise".

Finally, ***Locke*** identifies the three fundamental demerits which threatened the balance of state of nature. Firstly, the absence of a legal framework. Secondly, the lack of a "known and impartial judge". Thirdly, the requirement of an executive agency for the enforcement of decisions. Hence, the phenomenon of state was the means of liberation from this malady. Besides, it is worthwhile to keep in mind that the ***Locke*** an state of nature is inconsistent with facts. It rests on a fictional premise unsupported by any historical justification.

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